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VRscores: A New Measure and Data Set of Workforce Politics Using Voter Registrations

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Abstract. This paper introduces VRscores, a workplace-level measure of employee partisanship constructed by linking U.S. voter registrations to electronically available worker profiles covering 2012 to 2024. The resulting organizational-level data set captures the partisanship of 24.5 million workers across more than 534,000 employers with at least five matched employees. We release this employer-level data set along with parallel data sets reporting VRscores at the firm, occupation, industry, and metropolitan statistical area levels. We show that VRscores cover substantially more employees and organizations than donation-based approaches to measuring political ideology. We also show that VRscores are more representative of the U.S. workforce in terms of partisanship, seniority, occupation, and industry. Finally, we demonstrate that VRscores and donation-based measures are only moderately correlated ($r = 0.51$) and that they classify one in five organizations differently with respect to whether they lean Democratic or Republican.

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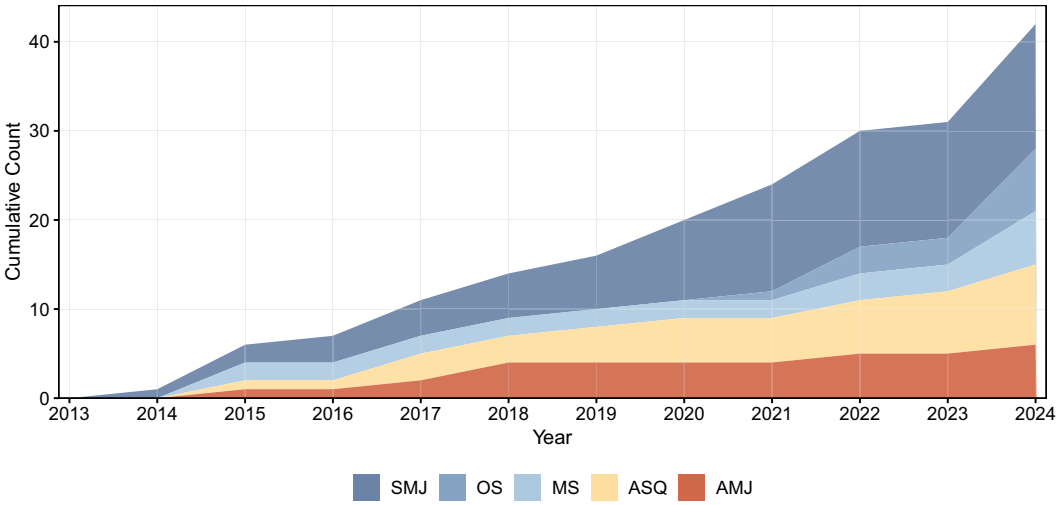
1. Introduction

A growing body of work considers how employees' political attitudes, beliefs, and identities might shape organizational outcomes. Early studies in this area focused on those within organizations' upper echelons, arguing that CEOs', board members', and top management team members' political ideologies shape diverse outcomes such as corporate social responsibility (CSR) (Chin et al. 2013), executive compensation (Gupta and Wowak 2017), gender equality (Carnahan and Greenwood 2018), and responses to social activism (Briscoe et al. 2014, McDonnell and Cobb 2020). More recently, scholars have considered how the political ideologies of rank-and-file workers relate to outcomes such as turnover (Bermiss and McDonald 2018, White et al. 2025), worker attraction and productivity (Carpenter and Gong 2015, Burbano 2021), personnel decisions (Mohliver and Raines 2024), sociopolitical activity (Gupta et al. 2017, Wowak et al. 2022, Li and Disalvo 2023, McKean and King 2024), and openness to external social activists (Gupta and Briscoe 2020).

To date, nearly all observational studies in this literature have operationalized employees' ideology using employees' political donations. This donations-based approach takes advantage of the fact that the Federal Election Commission (FEC) requires public disclosure of individual political donations to political campaigns and parties. The general approach is to aggregate donations from individual donors who report a common employer.[1] This measure is then scaled to reflect the proportion of donations flowing to one party (i.e., Democratic campaigns, committees, and/or the Democratic party) relative to the total donations to both major political parties (i.e., both Democratic and Republican recipients). This approach has been very influential, allowing scholars to open fruitful lines of research. As shown in Figure 1, we document 42 papers that use political contribution data and that appear in top management journals between 2013 and 2024.[2]

However, recent work draws attention to possible limitations regarding the coverage of donations-based measures, the validity of donations as indicators of

Figure 1. (Color online) Cumulative Number of Papers Using Political Donations Data in Top Management Journals



Note. AMJ, *Academy of Management Journal*; MS, *Management Science*; OS, *Organization Science*; ASQ, *Administrative Science Quarterly*; SMJ, *Strategic Management Journal*.

ideology, and the appropriateness of focusing on ideology rather than identity. With regard to coverage, exceedingly few workers donate (Stuckatz 2022a, Barber and Blake 2024, Teso 2025), and donors tend to be demographically distinct from nondonors (Grumbach and Sahn 2020, Grumbach et al. 2022, Bonica and Grumbach 2025) and hold extreme and atypical political views even relative to members of the same party (Bafumi and Herron 2010; Barber 2016a, b; Broockman and Malhotra 2020; Meisels et al. 2024; Barber et al. 2025). At the same time, recent work emphasizes how donations may not necessarily capture enduring political beliefs or attitudes but instead represent strategic attempts at impression management or gaining access to policymakers (Gordon et al. 2007, Werner 2015, Kalla and Broockman 2016, Barber and Blake 2023) or reflect coercion from workplace superiors (Hertel-Fernandez 2018, Babenko et al. 2020, Stuckatz 2022a). More broadly, in the years since the inception of the donations-based approach, political scientists have increasingly identified political identity (i.e., partisanship), rather than political ideology, as a key, stable driver of political attitudes and behaviors (Iyengar et al. 2012, Achen and Bartels 2016, Mason 2018).

In this paper, we introduce "voter registration scores" (VRscores) as a novel measure of organizational partisanship, which (1) provides significantly larger and more representative coverage across and within workplaces, (2) is less vulnerable to issues of strategic self-presentation, and (3) more directly captures workers' political identities. Our strategy takes advantage of the fact that voter registrations in the United States are publicly accessible and that the majority of registered voters can be linked to one of the two major political parties. By merging voter registration data with newly available large-scale data on employee work histories (see also Frake et al. 2024), we are able to identify the partisanship and place of employment for 45.3 million workers. After restricting to employers with at least five employees in our data set, our public data set contains the organizational partisanship of more than 534,000 employers based on 24.5 million workers.

After detailing how VRscores are created, we conduct a series of benchmarking exercises demonstrating VRscores' coverage advantages. First, because most of the working population is registered to vote, whereas only very few donate, VRscores capture far more workers (24.5 million in 2024) than donations-based measures (1.3 million donors during the most recent two-year federal election cycle). This larger sample yields a broader set of employers (534,000 versus 100,000) and significantly deeper coverage of each employer (45.9 registered voters per firm versus 25.5 donors). Second, we show that the sample of employees used to construct VRscores is more representative of the U.S. workforce in terms of partisan makeup, job category, and seniority. Whereas donations-based measures are heavily weighted toward relatively elite occupations and employees, VRscores better incorporate the political leanings of employees across occupations and throughout organizational hierarchies. We also show that VRscores and donations-based measures are only moderately correlated with each other and that VRscores deliver substantively different estimates regarding the distribution of partisanship within organizations.

We then review work suggesting that donations reflect strategic motivations rather than deeply held beliefs or values. Whereas Ansolabehere et al. (2003)'s influential work is often cited to claim that donations are purely ideologically motivated, empirical work in the intervening decades casts doubt on this assertion (Gordon et al. 2007, Kalla and Broockman 2016, Meisels

et al. 2024). In particular, we detail more recent work indicating that incentives for strategically motivated giving may exist for both (1) managers who wish to gain access to policymakers (Barber and Blake 2024, Teso 2025, Steel 2026), and (2) rank-and-file workers in response to pressure from superiors (Hertel-Fernandez 2018, Babenko et al. 2020, Stuckatz 2022a).

Next, we briefly summarize developments in political science in which scholars increasingly favor conceptions of political *identity* over political *ideology* for explaining political attitudes and behaviors (Iyengar et al. 2012). Notably, this work characterizes the majority of Americans as "ideologically innocent" and illustrates how political attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors often flow downstream from political identity (Achen and Bartels 2016, Kinder and Kalmoe 2017, Barber and Pope 2019, Kalmoe 2020). Far from being core and enduring characteristics, ideological beliefs are often quite malleable and tend to follow partisan identity cues rather than the other way around (Lenz 2012, Barber and Pope 2019). Given this, we encourage scholars who use VRscores to characterize these scores as measures of political identity (i.e., "organizational partisanship") rather than political ideology.

Having presented the advantages of VRscores, we discuss their possible limitations. With regard to limitations, we note that that VRscores can only capture workers with online professional profiles who are registered voters, as well as the possibility of strategic voter registration. Whereas we acknowledge that VRscores fall far short of perfection, the shortcomings we highlight are even more severe using alternative donations-based approaches.

We also provide practical guidance for scholars studying workforce politics more generally. We reiterate that measures of partisan identification and identity (i.e., Democrat versus Republican) cannot and should not always be treated as a proxy for ideology (i.e., liberal versus conservative). We especially caution against drawing ideological inferences about the ideology of unaffiliated individuals who do not identify with either political party (either through registration or donations), such as assigning a "neutral" ideology to those who decline to donate to either political party. We also remind researchers that all measures—whether VRscores or donations-based approaches—are less precisely estimated when they are based upon a small number of individual workers.

To close, we detail a range of applications for VRscores. In particular, we highlight how VRscores might be used to address underexplored questions regarding how the distribution of employees' partisanship relates to organizational outcomes, including performance, sociopolitical positioning, and corporate social responsibility. We also suggest that VRscores will be useful not only to management and strategy researchers but also to economists, political scientists, sociologists, and scholars in other business disciplines. We do not advocate the abandonment of donations as an object of study but instead highlight cases where it will be instructive to combine and compare VRscores with donations-based measures.

2. VRscores: A Registration-Based Measure of Partisanship

To begin, we detail the underlying data sources as well as the process by which they are combined to create VRscores. We term our measure "VRscores" in parallel with Bonica's widely used campaign finance scores ("CFscores") from the Database on Ideology, Money in Politics, and Elections (DIME) (Bonica 2014, 2016).

2.1. Voter Registration Files

Political parties in the United States do not maintain nationwide member rolls. Instead, each state maintains its own voter roll. In a majority of states, these rolls record each voter's party affiliation, if any. Like most other scholars, we rely on a vendor that aggregates voter files across all 50 states and Washington, DC.[3] Our data come from the nonpartisan vendor L2 Data, which has been widely used in academic research (e.g., Brown and Enos 2021, Imai et al. 2022). For every registered voter, the data contain information on geography (i.e., address), past turnout history, and partisan affiliation. In 30 states (and Washington, DC), voters may formally choose to be a member of a party during the registration process.

In the remaining states, L2 models partisanship based on fields such as past turnout in partisan primaries, historical data releases, or demographic modeling. These modeled partisan data have been widely used in political science research and have been validated with surveys (Igielnik et al. 2018). Additionally, given that a large majority of registered voters who do not register as either Democratic or Republican consistently behave like partisans (Keith et al. 1992, Petrocik 2009, Klar 2014, Klar and Krupnikov 2016), we follow the methodology developed by Brown and Enos (2021) and impute partisanship for nonpartisans. Our application of this methodology is detailed in the Online Appendix. In short, we impute partisanship based on primary participation as well as Bayesian methods using precinct-level electoral returns as well as demographic variables. Our final data release contains VRscores measures with and without these imputed partisans, allowing scholars to choose which approach they prefer and/or to check the sensitivity of using one approach over the other. (We discuss imputation further in Section 6.)

2.2. Online Worker Profiles

We measure work history with data from Revelio Labs, a vendor that aggregates online employment details from internet sites such as LinkedIn. Revelio data are increasingly used in management as well as other fields (e.g., Li et al. 2022, Frake et al. 2024). For each individual in the data set, Revelio records details related to both the specific position (i.e., the job) and the employer (i.e., the company). Position-level data include occupation and seniority. Revelio uses reported job titles to assign jobs to O*NET-SOC codes. Seniority is likewise assigned to one of seven categories ranging from entry level to senior executive based upon a model that incorporates job title, individual job history, and years of experience. We also rely upon position-level geographic data (i.e., metropolitan statistical area (MSA) of the job) to facilitate the matching process. Employer-level (company) data fields include the employer name and ultimate corporate parent, as well as the industry (NAICS). Revelio standardizes company names across variant spellings and maps subsidiaries to their ultimate corporate parent.

2.3. Merging Strategy

We detail the merging strategy by which we combine L2 and Revelio in the Online Appendix. Briefly, we use an ensemble linkage strategy that combines two complementary techniques: probabilistic and LLM-driven matching. First, we segment the data sets according to metropolitan statistical area (MSA), limiting potential matches to cases where the employment location and residential address fall within the same MSA. Second, we execute probabilistic record matching based on concordance patterns across comparison attributes including names, birth dates, and gender. We do so via Python's Splink package (Linacre et al. 2022), which implements the Fellegi–Sunter probabilistic matching framework (Fellegi and Sunter 1969) as adapted by Enamorado et al. (2019). Our second method utilizes the fuzzylink technique described by Ornstein (2024) to conduct embedding-based semantic linkage. This approach proved adept at identifying matches overlooked by the probabilistic approach. In instances where the methods yield inconsistent results, we give precedence to combinations with higher match probabilities and, in the rare case of a tie, randomly select which match to include in our data.

Our ensemble matching approach links 45.34 million Revelio users to voter registrations. Restricting to positions that remain active in 2024 yields 39.94 million workers across 4.14 million employers, or roughly 25% of the ≈ 160 million people in the 2024 U.S. workforce. Our VRscores data set further excludes employers with fewer than five matched workers. In the resulting employer-year panel, we track 24.53 million unique workers across 534,392 employers (an average of 45.9 matched workers per firm), equal to about 15% of the U.S. workforce in 2024. This coverage compares favorably to prior work by Colonnelli et al. (2022), who rely on administrative data (including a unique tax ID number) and are able to match 7.8% of Brazilian workers with a political party. Our matching approach also yields a larger number of matched workers than a contemporaneous study that follows a different matching approach based on slightly different source data (Chinoy and Koenen 2024). To gauge the quality of our matching procedure, we present illustrative matches in the Online Appendix (see Table A3).

2.4. Aggregating to Calculate VRscores

Using this matched data set, we calculate a VRscore for each employer that measures the aggregate partisan balance of its employees. Formally, a VRscore is defined as the number of total employees n who are Republican (R) over the number of employees who are either Democrats (D) or Republicans (R):

$$VRscore = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{n} \mathbb{I}(e_i = R)}{\sum_{i=1}^{n} \mathbb{I}(e_i = D) + \sum_{i=1}^{n} \mathbb{I}(e_i = R)}. \quad (1)$$

The choice of Republicans as the focal partisan group is mostly arbitrary, but has the feature of moving rightward from zero when plotted. Because VRscores are a two-party measure, researchers can calculate an alternative version focused on Democrats by simply subtracting the VRscore from one.

2.5. Public Data Set of VRscores

As a resource for scholars, we release the full VRscores data set for academic use.[4] The public data contains our full merge and year-specific VRscore estimates from 2012–2024 for all organizations with at least five matched workers. This public data set comprises several components. In addition to core VRscores, we also include linking identifiers where available. We also include replication code to reproduce the microdata as well as the figures and tables in this paper. Online Appendix Table A2 provides a sample of the data for the 50 largest firms in our sample.

To respect source licensing, the public release uses *VRID* as the employer identifier. *RCID* (Revelio Lab's proprietary company identifier), ultimate-parent *RCID*s, and crosswalk fields (e.g., *GVKEY*, ticker, exchange, FactSet identifiers, *CUSIP*, company URLs, LinkedIn URLs, NAICS codes/descriptions, and headquarters fields) are excluded from the public files and are available upon request to Revelio licensees via a restricted crosswalk.

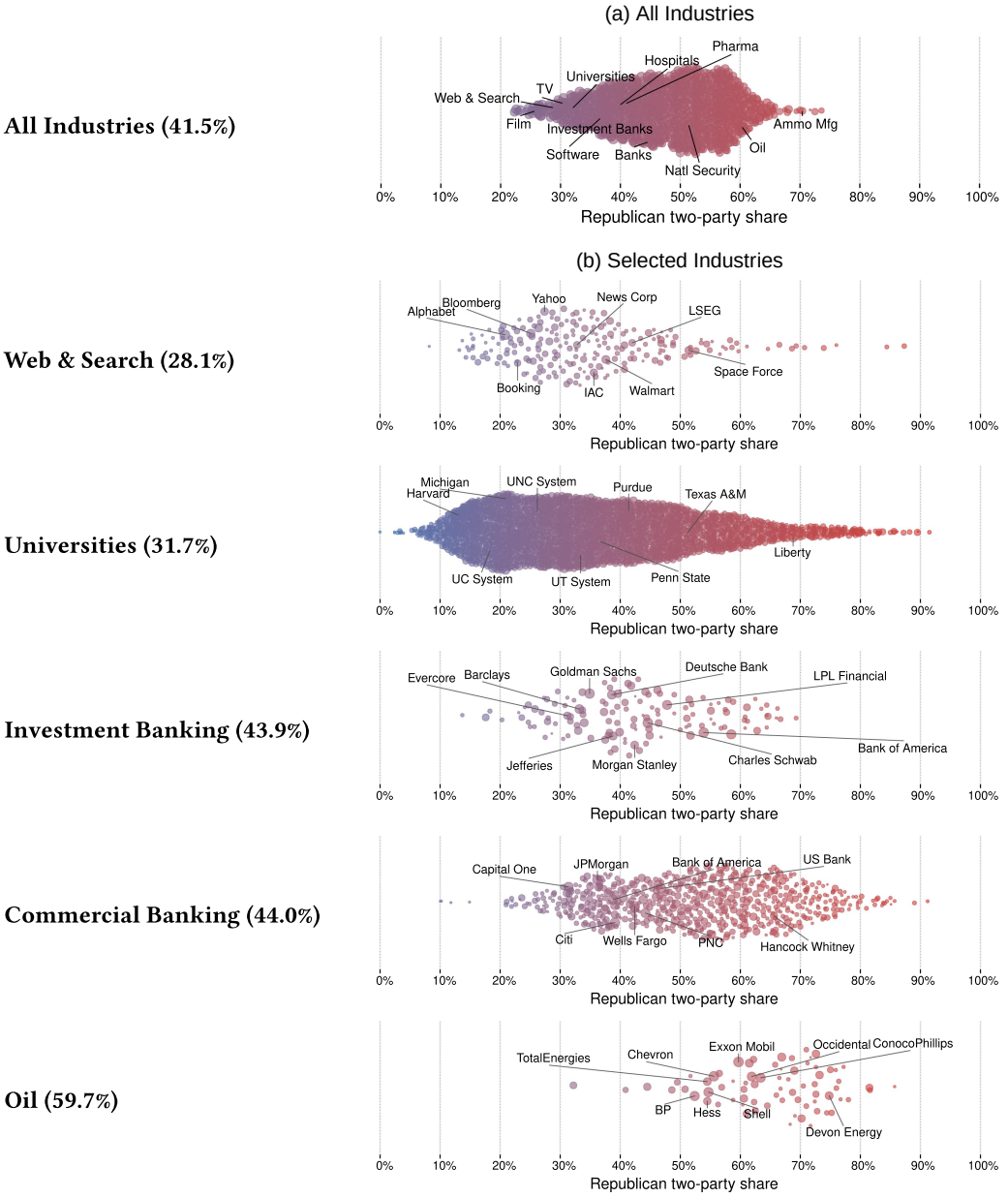
2.6. Industry- and Occupation-Level Patterns in VRscores

Having described how VRscores are calculated, we next visualize these scores to show how partisans are distributed across and within industries and occupations. In

these and all other cross-sectional analyses, we focus on the 2024 snapshot. Figure 2 visualizes this variation: Figure 2(a) plots the Republican share of workers *across* industries, and Figure 2(b) shows the distribution of firms *within* selected industries.

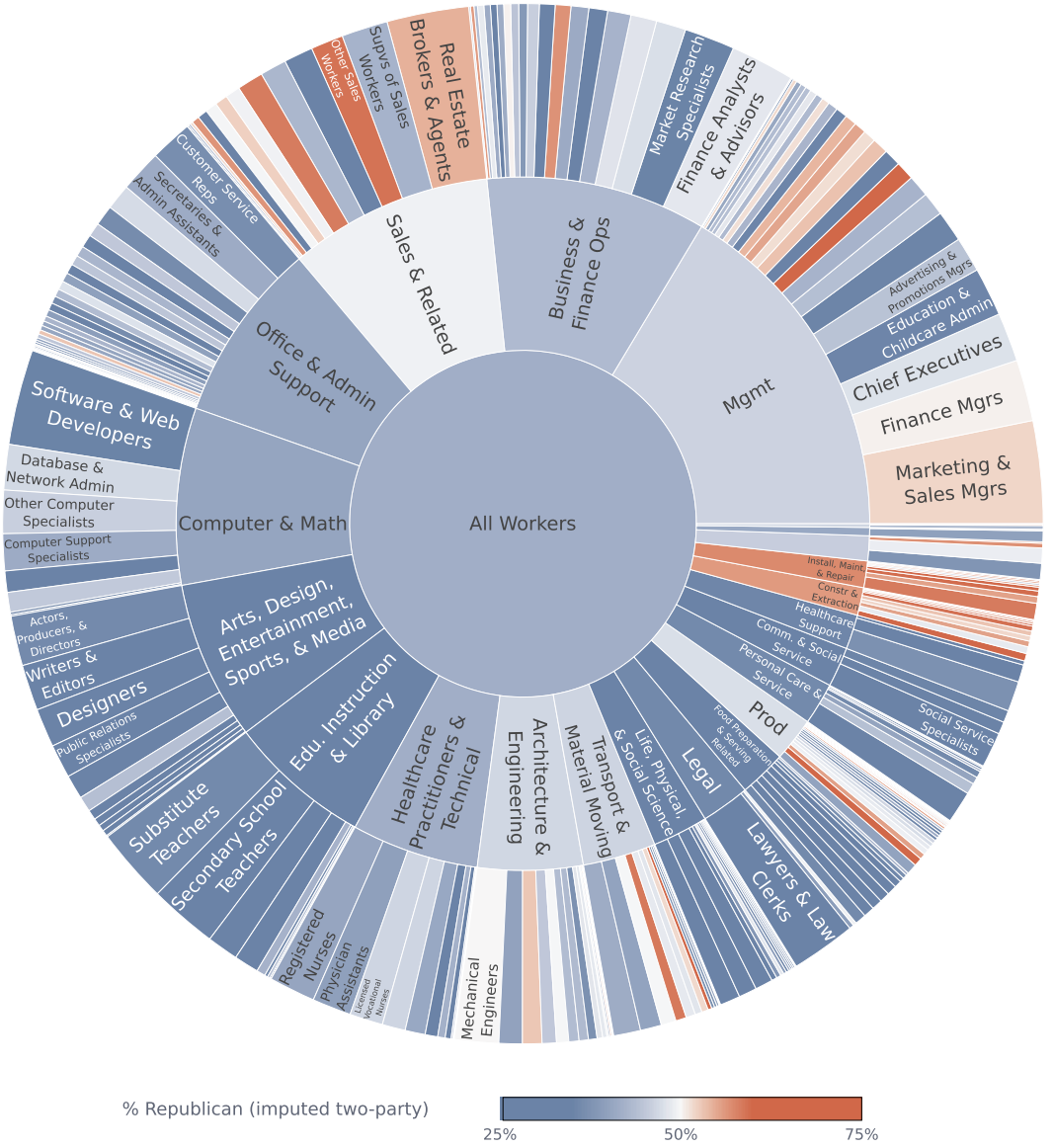
Figure 3 displays the Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) hierarchy as a sunburst, shading each node by the imputed two-party Republican share in 2024. This visualization highlights clear ideological clustering: education, social-service, and creative occupations are deep blue (e.g., *Miscellaneous Social Scientists and Related Workers* at 23% Republican), whereas extraction, construction, transport, and maintenance roles are shaded deep red (e.g., oil and gas drill operators reach roughly 70% Republican). Management and business services are more balanced, with customer-facing and administrative functions slightly right of center and technical/professional staff slightly left of center. Because node sizes scale with employment, the figure makes clear that the largest labor pools occupy the middle of the

Figure 2. (Color online) Distribution of VRscores by Industry and Organization (2024)



Notes. Plot depicts imputed two-party VRscores. For workers not registered as Democrats or Republicans, partisanship was imputed. The sample excludes workers whose partisanship could not be reliably imputed as Democratic or Republican. Points are scaled to reflect the number of workers. Figures in parentheses reflect the average two-party imputed *VRscore*.

Figure 3. (Color online) Partisanship of Occupations in VRscores (2024)



Notes. This sunburst plot aggregates the 2024 VRscores panel to the Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) hierarchy. The center shows the average VRscore across all workers with a valid occupation code in the data set (about 0.7% of workers do not have a valid occupational code assigned by Revelio); the first ring displays SOC major groups (two digit), and the second ring displays SOC broad occupations (four digit). Fine-grained SOC detailed occupations (six digit) are included in the public data set but are not plotted here to preserve readability. Slice area reflects the number of matched workers in each group. Shade gradient encodes the imputed two-party Republican share: blue shades indicate Democratic-leaning occupations, white indicates parity, and red shades indicate Republican-leaning occupations. Occupational labels are suppressed for groups representing less than about 1% of total employment.

distribution, with pockets of strongly partisan work at both extremes.

We also find notable geographic variation in workforce partisanship. Online Appendix Figure A9 illustrates the partisan lean of workers across U.S. regions, shading metropolitan areas by their VRscore Republican share. Broadly, coastal and urban areas tend to have more Democratic-leaning workforces, whereas many inland regions lean more Republican. This geographic pattern mirrors well-known red/blue regional splits.

These analyses show that VRscores recover clear, interpretable patterns in the political composition of the workforce (see also Chinoy and Koenen 2024, Frake et al. 2024). The industry beeswarms and occupational sunburst together summarize broad differences across sectors and job families and, crucially, reveal within-industry and within-occupation dispersion that researchers can leverage. In addition to the organization-level data release, we also release industry, occupation, and MSA-level VRscores.

3. Coverage Differences in Donations-Based Measures vs. VRscores

Next, we benchmark VRscores against donations-based measures across several dimensions. First, we examine the coverage of VRscores in terms of breadth of employee coverage (i.e., number of employees captured overall), breadth of employer coverage (i.e., number of employers present in the data), and depth of coverage within employers (i.e., number of employees per employer). Second, we benchmark the representativeness of VRscores versus donations-based measures in terms of political partisanship and the labor market roles of those covered. Third, we directly examine the correlation between VRscores and donations-based measures of aggregate employee partisanship.

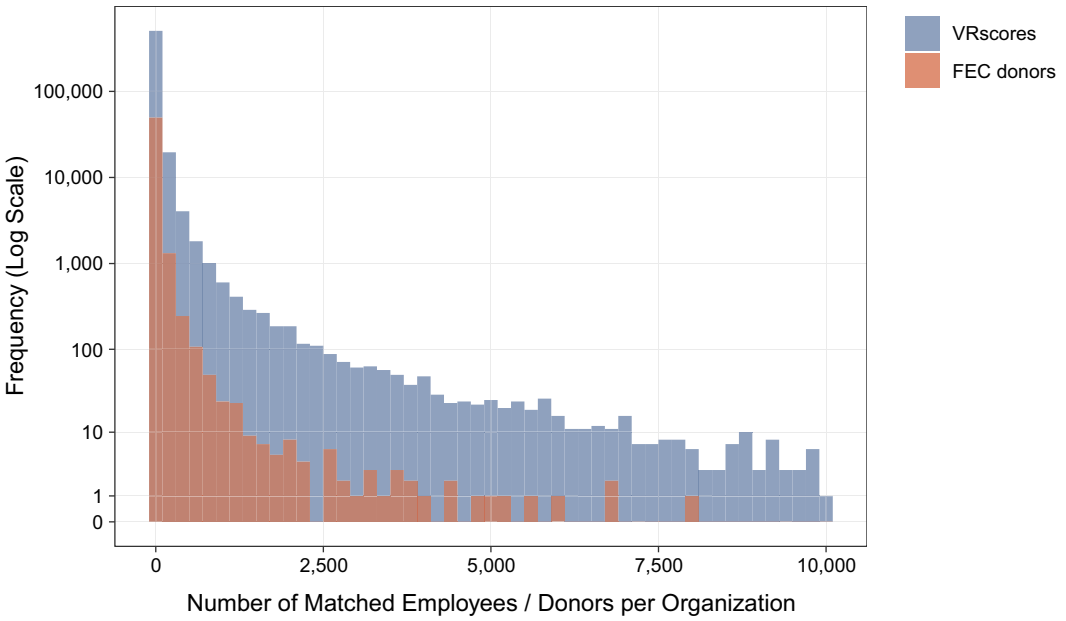
3.1. Breadth and Depth of Coverage

To compare the coverage of VRscores and donations-based measures of ideology, we first construct a donations-based metric. We access donations data from the Federal Election Commission and focus on the donations from the latest election cycle for which data were available at the time of our analysis (the 2023–2024 general election cycle). We then group individual donors by their (self-reported) employer. As the self-reported field is nonstandardized (Stuckatz 2022b), we first apply a detailed cleaning function to standardize employer names, the details of which are reported in the Online Appendix. Overall, the procedure produces 623,716 canonical employers, of which 58,869 consist of two or more raw variants. For the VRscores data, we aggregate positions active in 2024 by RCID.

Figure 4 compares, for 2024, the number of workers per employer in VRscores to the number of 2023–2024 FEC donors per employer. Note that the *y*-axis in this figure is on a log scale, so each labeled point is an order of magnitude larger than the previous point. Two patterns stand out. First, VRscores offer substantially *broader* coverage, capturing many more employers than the donations-based series. Second, VRscores provide *deeper* within-firm coverage: organizations that appear in the VRscores data typically have far more matched workers than FEC donors.

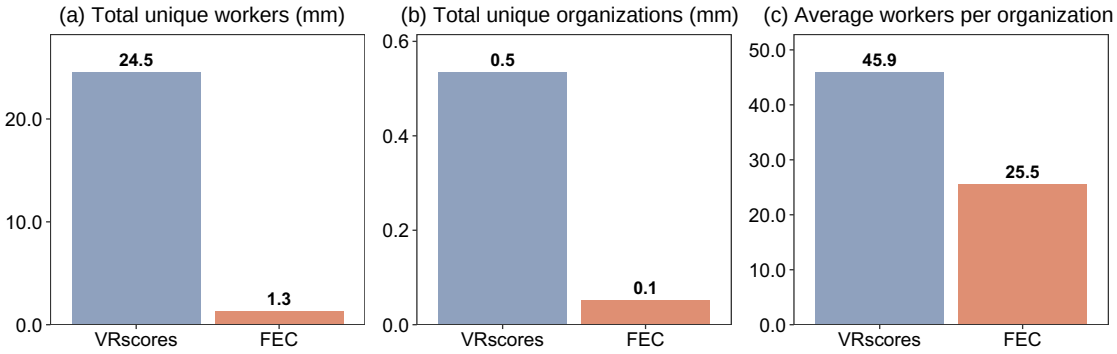
Figure 5 further disaggregates the dimensions along which VRscores outperform donations-based measures. Again, we include only organizations with five or more employees in each data set. We show that VRscores cover significantly more workers. VRscores contain data on approximately 24.5 million unique workers, compared with 1.3 million workers in the donations-based approach. This order-of-magnitude difference reflects the broader coverage of voter registration data. Whereas over three-quarters of employed Americans are registered to vote (Schaffner et al. 2023), only a very small proportion make political donations (Stuckatz 2022b). Second, VRscores cover many more unique employers (500,000 versus 100,000) with at least five identified workers than donations-based measures. This is consistent with Barber and Blake (2023), who estimate that as many

Figure 4. (Color online) Distribution of Employees per Employer (FEC vs. Revelio/L2)



Notes. The figure compares the number of matched registered voter employees per company in the 2024 VRscores data with the number of matched donors per employer in the 2024 FEC data. The *y*-axis uses a $\log(n+1)$ (natural-log) transform so zero and single-count bins remain visible, and the *x*-axis is truncated at 10,000; both series exclude organizations with fewer than five matched employees or donors. VRscores positions active in 2024 are rolled up to companies using the *RCID*.

Figure 5. (Color online) Comparison of FEC and VRscores



Notes. VRscores totals are computed from the 2024 matched panel by aggregating employees at the company *RCID*; FEC totals aggregate 2024 donors to the canonical employer groups described in Figure 3 (lowercasing, punctuation removal, standardized corporate suffixes, token blocking, and term frequency-inverse document frequency (TF-IDF) clustering). Both data sets retain only employers with at least five matched employees or donors.

as 60% of firms have no political donors among their employees.

Finally, VRscores also outperform donations-based measures in terms of the number of workers *within* each firm. To make this comparison, we conduct a perfect match of employers and only compare those for which we have five registered voters and five FEC donors. On average, VRscores cover 46 workers per employer, whereas donations-based metrics calculate the firm average based on 26 individual employee donors.

Beyond this relative comparison with donations-based approaches, we also examine breadth and depth against some absolute metrics. First, we confirmed that our data covers all companies listed in the 2025 U.S. Fortune 500 and S&P 500. Second, we gathered the list of all publicly traded companies using Compustat. After removing ETFs, indices, and other financial securities that technically constitute publicly traded companies but do not have employees, we estimate that we cover approximately 90% of all publicly traded U.S. companies.

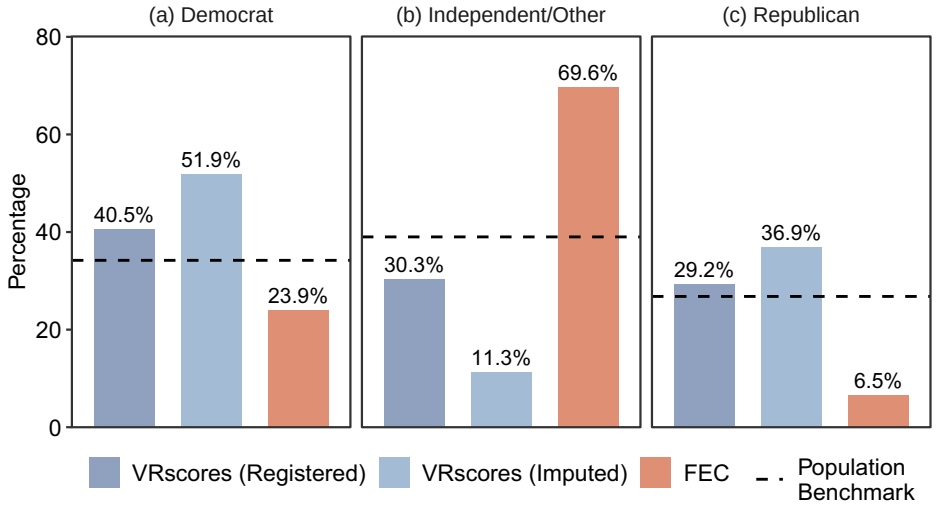
Finally, we gauge within-firm coverage against third-party estimates of organizational headcount. To do this, we benchmark the number of matches employees within VRscores against Compustat estimates of firm size as well as the total number of employees found in Revelio (which includes workers who we are unable to match. Figure A8 in the Online Appendix reports (1) Compustat's most recent 2024 headcount from WRDS, (2) Revelio headcounts (all Revelio users as well as only Revelio workers found in MSAs), and (3) VRscores headcounts based on positions active in 2024 in the matched Revelio/L2 data set, rolled up to the parent GVKEY. On these matched samples, VRscores headcounts average roughly 9% of Compustat headcount and 19% of all Revelio workers among all public firms (Figure A8(a)), and about 12% of Compustat and 20% of Revelio (All) for the Fortune 1,000 subset (Figure A8(b)). Relative to the MSA-only Revelio extract (i.e., those present in Revelio who we attempt to match), the corresponding coverage is approximately 27% (all firms) and 28% (Fortune 1000).

3.2. Representativeness

We next investigate how employee donors compare with nondonors in terms of representativeness along both political and labor market–related dimensions. To do this, we return to the matched data set used to assemble company-level VRscores and take advantage of additional data fields from L2 and Revelio. First, L2 records whether individual registered voters made political contributions during the past four electoral cycles. We use this field to split our matched sample into donors and nondonors. We then compare donors and nondonors in our sample in terms of their political partisanship (from L2) and the nature of their employment (from Revelio). We benchmark political representativeness using high-quality survey data (the 2022 Cooperative Election Survey) and employment details using figures from the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) and the Census Bureau's American Community Survey (ACS).

3.2.1. Partisan Representativeness. First, in Figure 6, we compare the 2024 partisan composition of workers using two VRscores series—one based on registered partisanship and one using imputed partisanship—against the partisan composition of FEC donors aggregated to employers (*RCID*). We benchmark each to the 2022 Cooperative Election Study, which allows us to examine self-identified party identification for validated voters in full-time or part-time employment. The panels report the shares of Democrats, Independents/Other, and Republicans; the VRscores series restricts to employers with at least five matched workers active in 2024, and the FEC series restricts to employers with at least five distinct donors in the 2023–2024 cycle.

Figure 6. (Color online) Demographic Comparison by Political Affiliation



Notes. Figure compares the 2024 partisan composition of the VRscores data set, FEC donors, and population-level benchmarks drawn from the 2022 Cooperative Election Study. We plot two VRscores series—one using only registered partisanship and one using imputed partisanship—each restricted to employers with at least five matched workers whose positions are active in 2024. The FEC series aggregates by employer, which are defined in the same way as Figure 3 (lowercasing, punctuation removal, standardized corporate suffixes, token blocking, TF-IDF clustering), retaining only organizations that have at least five distinct donors over the 2023–2024 federal cycle. Donor partisan counts reflect sums by committee affiliation; individuals who contribute to both Democratic and Republican committees appear in each corresponding total. FEC donor partisanship reflects the affiliation of the donation; contributors and committees without a clear Democratic or Republican lean (including blanks, third-parties, and issue organizations) fall into the Independent/Other category. Dotted lines denote CES voter registration partisanship among labor force participants, which may differ from self-identification. Whereas neither data set perfectly matches the CES benchmark, both VRscores series hew far more closely to the population than the FEC donor distribution.

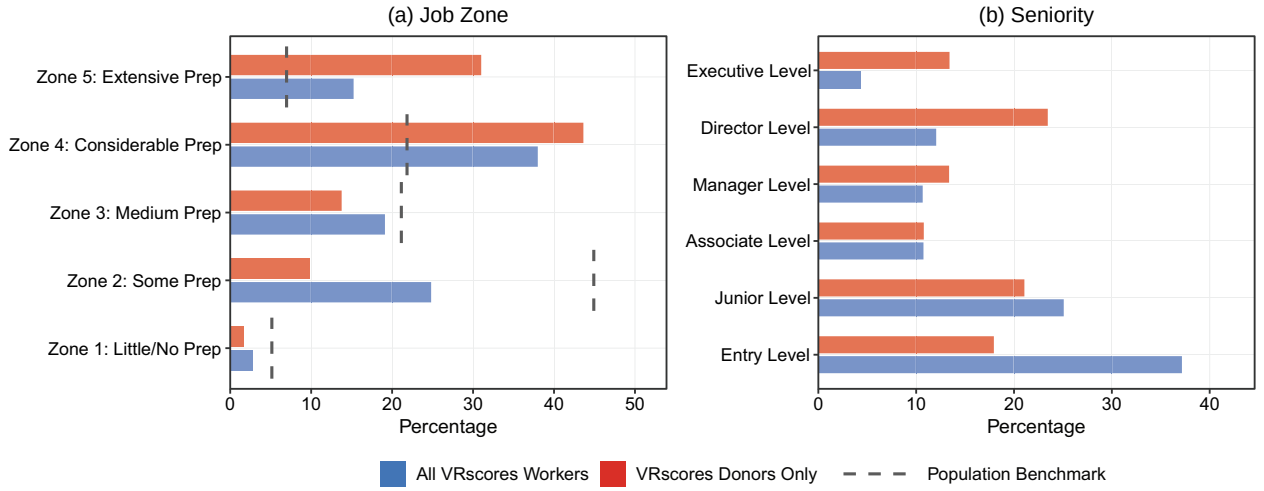
Both VRscores track the CES benchmark more closely than the FEC donor distribution. In the FEC series, a large fraction of observations fall into the Independent/Other category because donations without a clear partisan affiliation (including third parties, issue committees, or donors who give to both sides) are coded as Independent/Other. As a result, the FEC Democratic and Republican shares are markedly lower than both the VRscores series and the population benchmark. By contrast, the VRscores registered and imputed variants differ in how unaffiliated registrants are treated, with imputation modestly increasing the partisan shares. Whereas our main VRscore is a two-party Republican share (excluding "Others" from the denominator), we also report the share of "Others" as supplemental information. By contrast, it is not clear how to incorporate Independents/nonpartisans in donations-based measures.[5]

3.2.2. Labor Market Representativeness. Next, we examine the labor market representativeness of donors versus matched registered voters. We benchmark along two dimensions. First, we look at the level of individual workers and compare the larger set of workers who are registered voters with the smaller set of workers who make political donations. Second, we look at the level of employers and compare coverage across sectors of the economy.

We first assess labor market representativeness by comparing donors to nondonors across two-digit Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) codes in Figure A6 in the Online Appendix. Next, we use the Job Zone classifications developed by the U.S. Department of Labor. The Job Zone typology groups occupations into five areas based on the levels of education, experience, and on-the-job training required to perform the job. Job Zone One represents entry-level jobs with little or no formal education or preparation needed (e.g., landscaping or housekeeping), whereas Zone Five occupations require extensive preparation, usually in the form of graduate school (e.g., lawyers or physicians). Figure 7(a) illustrates the distribution of matched registered voters and donors across the job zone classifications, along with a population benchmark from BLS figures from May 2024.

Given that both the likelihood of registering to vote and the likelihood of having a professional online presence are positively associated with education, income, and socioeconomic status (Verba et al. 1995), it is not surprising that both measures are somewhat skewed toward workers in higher zones. Both the overall registered voter sample and the donor employee sample underrepresent workers in occupations that require less preparation (zones one and two), although the extent of the coverage gap is substantially larger for donors than our matched sample of registered voters. The most

Figure 7. (Color online) Distributions of Workers by Job Zone and Seniority



Notes. This figure compares the 2024 occupational mix of the VRscores workforce ("All VRscores Workers") with the subset identified by L2 as reportable FEC donors ("VRscores Donors Only"). Counts are based on distinct individuals whose positions are active in 2024. (a) Workers grouped by O*NET Job Zone. The dashed benchmark is derived from the BLS May 2024 Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics release ("national_M2024_dl.xlsx"). (b) Workers grouped by Revelio seniority. We combine Revelio's level 6 (Executive) and level 7 (Senior Executive) into the "Executive Level."

dramatic coverage skew is found for workers in the highest zone. Whereas the BLS estimates that only around 7% of workers fall into this category, about one-third of donors fall into this category, meaning donations-based metrics dramatically overweight the politics of a numerically small but highly elite subset of the workforce (see also Stuckatz 2022a, Teso 2025).

We next examine how donors compare with nondonors regarding their positions within organizational hierarchies. We take advantage of the seniority variable created by Revelio, which classifies individuals' seniority into seven levels based upon their job title and years of relevant experience. Figure 7(b) shows that the population of donors is significantly skewed toward managers, directors, and executives, whereas matched registered voters are skewed toward entry- and junior-level workers. Whereas we lack a direct population-level benchmark, the distribution of VRscores—that is, one that includes far more junior workers than senior executives—appears to comport far better with how most organizations are structured. By contrast, the donor sample is more uniformly distributed across seniority levels, providing further evidence that the donor base is unrepresentatively senior.

Finally, we examine the distribution of matched registered voters versus donors across industry sectors compared with baseline population figures from the 2022 ACS. Figure A5 in the Online Appendix shows that donors are significantly more likely to come from Information, Finance, and Professional Services, whereas matched registered voters are significantly more likely to come from Leisure and Hospitality and Retail Trade. These patterns bear similarities to the preceding two exercises, indicating that donors are relatively more concentrated in jobs that require more education and provide higher pay. Whereas the preceding exercises highlighted concerns that donations-based measures may be less representative than VRscores at accurately representing individuals within specific firms, Figure A5 suggests that analyses based upon donation scores may capture a set of employers that are unrepresentative vis-à-vis the economy as a whole. Specifically, measures based on donations may include only employers in certain types of industries where workers are generally more educated and better compensated.

3.3. Intertemporal Stability

As a brief aside, we also highlight the intertemporal stability of VRscores. Donations are, by definition, discrete, election-specific actions, characterized by significant intertemporal variation. Registered partisanship, in contrast, is an enduring, generally stable individual characteristic. To demonstrate how this individual-level stability translates into organizational stability, we calculate the within-employer standard deviation of VRscores and then plot the distribution of these values in Online Appendix Figure A3(a). This shows that the year-to-year partisan mix of a given employer tends to vary only modestly (with a median within-firm standard deviation under 10 percentage points), indicating that workforce partisanship is a persistent organizational attribute.

3.4. Direct Employer-Level Comparison

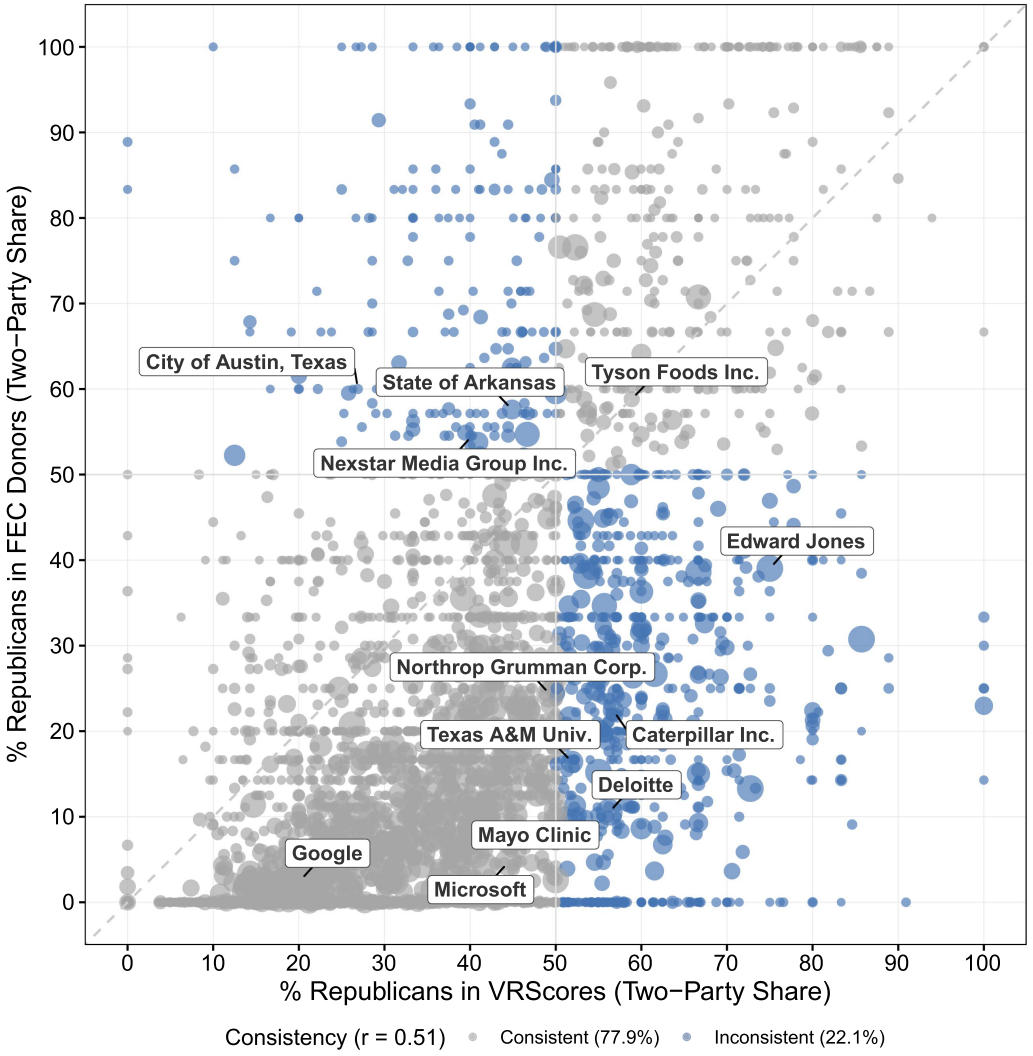
Having documented significant differences in the breadth, depth, and representativeness of the individual employees who comprise VRscores relative to donations-based

measures, we now compare the company-level measures directly. This comparison requires matching organizations between our data set and the FEC donations data set. We match organizations across data sets by reusing the canonical employer names generated for Figure 4 and replicating that text cleaning in VRscores before performing a deterministic join, resulting in 4,141 distinct organizational matches between our data sets.

3.4.1. Correlation Analysis. In Figure 8, we examine the correlation between the percentage of Republican employees (two-party share) across firms using both VRscores (x-axis) and the donations-based metric (y-axis). We find only a moderate correlation between these measures ($r = 0.51$), suggesting that the political composition of employee donors is meaningfully distinct from the overall aggregate balance of employees. In addition to the overall correlation, the scatterplot also reveals that more than one in five (22%) organizations differ between the two measures in whether they are classified as majority Democratic or majority Republican.[6] These substantial discrepancies further underscore the distinction between VRscores and prior existing donations-based approaches as well as the need for researchers to carefully consider which measure is most appropriate for their topic of inquiry.

Next, we compare the VRscores data set to the Mannor and Busenbark (2025) donations-based measures of

Figure 8. (Color online) Correlation Between VRscores and Donations-Based Measure of Firm Politics



Notes. Scatterplot compares Republican two-party shares derived from the 2024 VRscores data set (x-axis) with the 2024 FEC employer aggregates (y-axis). We match organizations across data sets by reusing the canonical employer names generated for Figure 4 and replicating that text cleaning in VRscores before performing a deterministic join. The figure keeps only matches with at least five two-party workers in the VRscores snapshot and at least five two-party donors in the FEC data, leaving 4,141 distinct employers. Labels highlight several large, notable organizations across quadrants. Figure A1 in the Online Appendix repeats the exercise weighting the FEC axis by donation amounts (dropping employers with fewer than $100 in two-party giving), and the patterns are substantively unchanged.

political ideology (DIPI) by matching the two data sets on Compustat's *GVKEY*. Because DIPI only covers publicly traded companies, this comparison is only among publicly traded firms with a valid *GVKEY* in VRscores and DIPI. In Figure A2 in the Online Appendix, we compare the 2024 VRscores with the most recent version of the DIPI data (2022). Each panel plots the share of Republicans in VRscores against the share of Republican donors in DIPI (using their 10-year measures). Figure A2(a) compares employee-level VRscores to employee donations, whereas Figure A2, (b) to (d) compares VRscores to donations from top management teams (TMTs), CEOs, and boards, respectively. Agreement between the two measures is moderate for employees ($r = 0.51$, 73% consistent) and somewhat lower for top management teams ($r = 0.31$), CEOs ($r = 0.30$), and directors ($r = 0.36$).

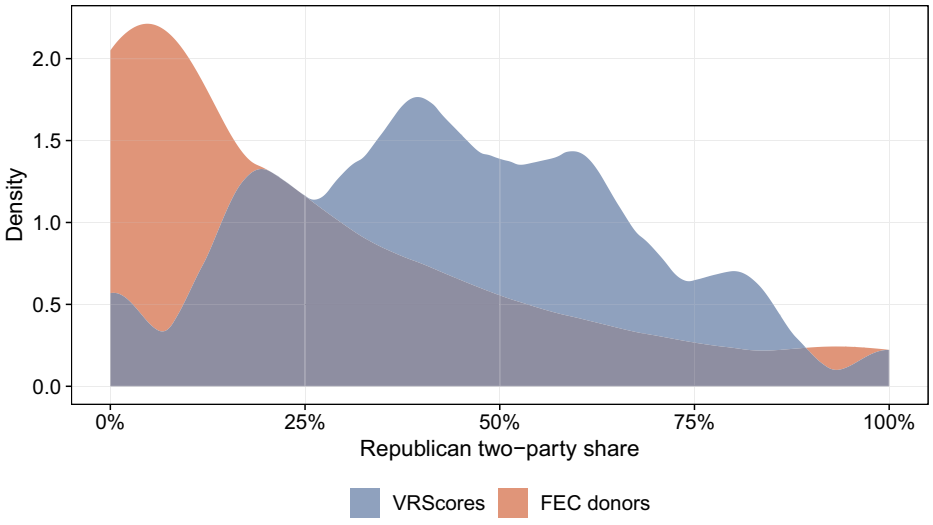
As a final exercise to illustrate substantive differences in these measures, we chart, in Figure 9, the distribution of the share of workers who are Republicans for these matched sets of firms separately as measured using the donations-based approach and VRscores. This figure shows that the donations-based measure follows a skewed distribution, with many firms classified as very heavily Democratic. In contrast, the distribution of VRscores has much more mass across the middle of the distribution. This exercise demonstrates that VRscores capture significant levels of political diversity in organizations that donations-based measures characterize as left leaning. More generally, it indicates that employers in the United States are not as politically homogeneous or skewed in terms of their workforce as the donations-based measure might suggest.

We also assess whether these differences persist across firms of varying sizes. Online Appendix Figure A4 replicates the comparison in Figure 9 for subsamples defined by firm size cutoffs. Across small, medium, and large employers, the donations-based metric consistently exhibits a skewed pattern (i.e., overwhelmingly Democratic), whereas the VRscores distributions remain more centered. In other words, the tendency for VRscores to capture greater within-firm political diversity holds at different firm size thresholds.

4. Donations May Be Strategic Rather than Expressive

Having empirically demonstrated coverage advantages of VRscores, we next consider conceptual challenges arising from the fact that donations may be strategic rather than expressive. Inferring ideological preferences from observed donations requires assuming that donors give to candidates who they perceive as ideologically aligned with themselves. This assumption is frequently justified with reference to Ansolabehere et al. (2003), who reason that because the average donation is too small to impact election results, donors have no incentive to give except to candidates who mirror their ideological preferences. Referencing this work, for instance, Chin et al. (2013, p. 207) argue that "[a]lthough some political giving is motivated by a desire for influence, political scientists have concluded that donations from individuals … are overwhelmingly motivated by personal

Figure 9. (Color online) Distribution of Share of Republican Workers for VRscores vs. Donations-Based Measure (Employee Donors)



Notes. Kernel density plots compare 2024 Republican two-party shares for all VRscores employers (imputed party labels with more than five matched workers active in 2024; 485,610 organizations) to FEC employers (more than five unique donors in the 2023–2024 cycle; 16,711 organizations). VRscores shares are computed from imputed Democratic and Republican worker counts. Densities are estimated with a biweight kernel (bandwidth adjustment 2).

ideology." More recently, Wowak et al. (2022, p. 567) argue that "political psychologists have concluded that individuals' political donations are expressions of ideological preferences or personal value systems, rather than efforts to obtain political favors." A recent methodological paper describing the donations-based measure (Mannor and Busenbark 2025) makes this same claim.

Work in the decades since Ansolabehere et al. (2003) challenges the conclusion that personal ideology is the only significant driver of political donations. Gordon et al. (2007), for example, point out that if donations are primarily expressive, donors would give even to poor-quality candidates in uncompetitive elections, as long as they are a close ideological fit. Empirically, this is not the case. Instead, donors take into account strategic electoral considerations such as candidate electability and district competitiveness (Meisels et al. 2024). Similarly, donors also prefer to give to candidates in their home districts even if they may be less ideologically aligned relative to candidates in other districts (Bouton et al. 2024).

Beyond this general evidence that donations are strategic, there is more specific evidence that career and employment concerns induce strategic giving. Within this work, one strand of literature has examined donations by executives. Kim et al. (2026), for example, link 75 million lobbying reports and campaign contributions, showing that senior corporate officials are significantly more likely to make donations to elected officials whom they lobby in the future. In related work, Teso (2025) confirms that corporate elites are more likely to donate to Congress members whom their companies are lobbying and who sit on committees with oversight over their companies' industries.[7] Richter and Werner (2017) show that CEOs use political donations, in lieu of PACs, to circumvent regulatory or public scrutiny while accessing politicians. Work in progress by Barber and Blake (2023) provides direct evidence of strategic giving, showing a significant discontinuity in how much and to which parties workers donate when they become CEOs or join boards.

Other work substantiates the strategic advantages of these actions, showing how donations yield material benefits to those who make them. For example, Kalla and Broockman (2016) show via a randomized field experiment that access-seeking organizations were significantly more likely to be granted meetings with members of Congress when they revealed that members of their staff had donated to the member. Using large-scale donations data, Steel (2026) shows that CEOs who strategically donate to influential lawmakers can diminish the severity of regulatory enforcement penalties.

If strategic giving were limited to top executives, this might be less concerning, especially in cases where scholars remove top executives when calculating donations-based measures. However, strategic incentives to donate are not limited to upper echelons because managers frequently influence the donation patterns of rank-and-file subordinates. In a series of national surveys, Hertel-Fernandez (2018) estimates that nearly 25% of workers have had a manager try to mobilize them in support of a political cause or candidate and that 50% of managers report attempting to mobilize subordinates. This pressure tends to push employees toward positions that will benefit their employer but are inconsistent with their personal beliefs (Hertel-Fernandez 2017). Babenko et al. (2020) illustrate how this pressure manifests in donations, demonstrating that candidates supported by firm CEOs also receive more support from these CEOs' subordinates. Stuckatz (2022a) presents similar evidence, illustrating that workers adjust their donation patterns to match the donation patterns of their employer's political action committees (PACs). Interviews with private equity professionals suggest that workers' mimicry of their superiors' donation patterns may reflect not only coercion but also impression management by junior workers who attempt to curry favor with superiors (Bermiss and McDonald 2018).

Both sets of mechanisms—that is, top-down pressure from superiors or strategic impression management on the part of subordinates—are made possible by the fact that donations are more publicly visible than voting registrations. At many employers, executives may explicitly solicit donations from subordinates and coworkers by circulating a list of the company's preferred candidates (Li 2018). Furthermore, the website OpenSecrets makes donation records accessible such that anyone can look up the political donations for anyone else—including, for example, executives who wish to see whether their subordinates supported the company's preferred candidate or other stakeholders who wish to see which party a CEO supports. By contrast, there is often no straightforward analogue to looking up a single voter's partisan registration. Whereas one can purchase an individual states' entire voter rolls, many states charge substantial fees and/or restrict access to parties with a valid need to know (e.g., political campaigns or researchers).

5. Ideology vs. Identity

So far, we have outlined reasons why VRscores may be more accurate in capturing the partisan skew than donations-based approaches are in capturing ideological skew; the former provides better coverage across and within firms and is less vulnerable to strategic manipulation. However, it is important to underscore that donations-based approaches seek to measure a different construct. Whereas donations-based approaches have sought to capture political *ideology*—meaning enduring, stable, sets of political attitudes, beliefs, and values—VRscores capture political *identity*, meaning the political group to which one belongs, generally

understood as one's political partisanship (Jost 2006, Iyengar et al. 2012, Swigart et al. 2020). Leaving aside concerns over empirical accuracy, we also highlight developments in the field of political science that increasingly favor conceptions of political identity over political ideology when characterizing the drivers of political polarization and behavior.

Trepidation regarding the measurement and prevalence of political ideology dates at least to Converse (1964), who demonstrated that self-reported political attitudes, values, and beliefs were surprisingly unstable and inconsistent among the majority of the public. In a more contemporary version of this analysis, Kinder and Kalmoe (2017) illustrate that most Americans are "ideologically innocent" in the sense that they lack organized, constrained belief systems along liberal-conservative dimensions. Relatedly, political ideology is only very weakly correlated with differences in personality traits among the mass population (Kalmoe 2020).

In and alongside this work, scholars have increasingly shown the advantages of considering political identity, as it constitutes a temporally stable individual attribute with consistent predictive power for political attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors (Green et al. 2002, Iyengar et al. 2012). This research suggests that group identity—that is, political partisanship—tends to proceed policy positions and ideology, rather than the other way around. For example, research has shown that individuals' policy preferences and attitudes can be influenced by political elites (Lenz 2012, Dias and Lelkes 2022). Barber and Pope (2019) show that self-described conservatives reverse their attitudes on longstanding "conservative" policy issues when told that "liberal" policies were supported by Donald Trump. Whereas it is true that parties have become more ideologically homogeneous (i.e., there are few liberal Republicans), Ellis and Stimson (2012) argue that "symbolic" ideology and self-identification with an ideological label do not necessarily coincide with "operational" ideology that reflects actual policy preferences. Summarizing a huge body of work, Achen and Bartels (2016) propose that an identity-based conception of political behavior is superior to the "folk theory of democracy" wherein actions and attitudes follow sequentially from stable, coherent political ideologies.

This conception of political partisanship as identity has proven especially fruitful in elucidating the drivers of affective polarization (Mason 2018), explaining how ostensibly nonpolitical questions or contexts take on a partisan valence (Benton et al. 2021) and demonstrating how political beliefs and values can flow downstream from political identities (Barber and Pope 2019). Whereas a comprehensive discussion of the theoretical and empirical nuances of the ideology versus identity debate is beyond the scope of this paper, we wish to emphasize that our approach directly captures political identity in the form of political partisanship. Whereas partisanship and ideology are undoubtedly connected, we suggest that scholars who use voter registrations (VRscores) to characterize these measures as reflecting political identity (i.e., "organizational partisanship") rather than a measure of political ideology because they more directly capture the former.[8]

6. Limitations of VRscores

We argue that there are strong empirical and theoretical reasons to use VRscores to measure organizational politics. However, these measures are not flawless. Here, we discuss some notable limitations of VRscores and compare these limitations to other donations-based approaches. Whereas we urge researchers remain mindful of the limitations of VRscores, we believe that these measures are often more appropriate than donations-based measures for many research questions commonly posed in organizational research. To assist future research, we discuss these limitations here and provide practical guidance for researchers studying workforce politics in the next section.

6.1. VRscores Only Capture Online Workers

First, VRscores can only capture workers with online profiles on websites such as LinkedIn.[9] However, not all workers use LinkedIn. In particular, LinkedIn use is more common in many white-collar industries (e.g., professional services and finance) than in more blue-collar industries (e.g., agriculture and manufacturing) (Chinoy and Koenen 2024, Frake et al. 2024). Whereas the industry skew of VRscores compares favorably to donations-based measures (which are even more skewed toward white-collar industries), this remains a limitation that scholars should bear in mind.

Related evidence suggests that Democrats are more likely than Republicans to use LinkedIn (Vogels et al. 2021). This may bias VRscores away from the true ratio of Democrats to Republicans. Whereas this may bias two-party estimates away from their true population value, the relative underrepresentation of Republicans is unlikely to systematically vary from firm to firm. Perhaps most importantly, other work in progress using the same underlying data shows that the partisan composition of this matched data set matches the partisan composition of working, registered voters (Frake et al. 2024).

6.2. VRscores Only Capture Registered Voters

Another concern is that VRscores only capture registered voters, omitting the nearly one in four employed American workers who are not registered to vote (Schaffner et al. 2023, Frake et al. 2024). The population of workers who are not registered voters is comprised of two principal groups: workers who are legally ineligible to register to vote and workers who are eligible to vote but decline to do so.

The most notable group of noneligible voters is noncitizens, who constitute a nonnegligible portion of the U.S. workforce. Kramer and Passel (2025) estimate that there are approximately 22 million authorized and 8.3 million unauthorized immigrant workers. Together, these constitute nearly 18% of the workforce. The actual number of workers without the right to vote is likely somewhat lower, as nearly half of all authorized immigrants are naturalized U.S. citizens with the right to vote. The significance of this limitation may depend on the specific research question, as companies, industries, and occupations differ in the extent to which they employ noncitizen workers, as well as the extent to which noncitizens may be politically active.[10] Notably, because noncitizens are legally prohibited from making political donations, this limitation is equally applicable to the donations-based approach.[11]

The (non)coverage of eligible-but-unregistered voters is more theoretically nuanced and depends on which dimension of politics the research question considers. For studies explicitly interested in partisanship, a reliance upon voter data means that, very strictly speaking, there are no missing data because nonregistered voters do not have a registered partisanship to be measured. In cases in which researchers wish to characterize the political beliefs and attitudes of employees in aggregate—including those not captured by VRscores—researchers must make auxiliary assumptions. The extent to which this matters will vary greatly across contexts based on the proportion of nonregistered or ineligible voters and the comparability of registered voters and nonregistered voters. Additional considerations that may inform how researchers navigate this issue include the fact that nonregistered voters are far less politically engaged in general (Verba et al. 1995). Needless to say, this concern is far greater with donations-based measures, given the extreme rarity of political donations among the general population.

6.3. Voters May Register Strategically

Another concern is that registered partisanship, like political donations, may sometimes reflect strategic calculation rather than true political identity. This may occur for several reasons. First, individuals who reside in deep blue or red states with closed primaries may choose to register with the majority party, rather than the party with which they truly identify, in order to vote in competitive partisan primaries.[12] Whereas some voters probably do engage in this form of strategic registration, recent analysis suggests this practice is very rare. In the 2022 Cooperative Election Survey (Schaffner et al. 2023), an estimated 1% of U.S. adults identified as members of a political party but also stated that they were registered with the opposing political party. This already-small figure may be driven more by voter inattention or long-term political shifts rather than strategic motivations, as other work argues that party affiliation is more driven by "true" preferences and only very rarely by strategic considerations with regard to primary access (Guo 2023). Consistent with this idea, voters moving from "open" to "closed" primary states are no more likely to change their partisanship than voters moving from states with similar primary election procedures (Cantoni and Pons 2022).

Second, just as political donors may avoid disclosing their employer to avoid scrutiny (Shanor et al. 2022), individuals may also be aware that their party registration is public and may thus tailor their official registration because of social pressure. In practice, this also appears unlikely. Whereas it is technically possible for everyday citizens to access voter registrations (i.e., to investigate one's colleagues), many states place restrictions on access that make it expensive and time-consuming to access voter rolls.[13] Once again, we acknowledge this potential concern but highlight that it is far more present when using donations-based measures. Whereas the potential for strategic registration remains possible but almost entirely theoretical, strategic donations have been well documented (e.g., Barber and Blake 2023).

7. Practical Guidance on Studying Workforce Politics

In addition to describing potential limitations of VRscores for researchers to bear in mind, we also provide specific guidance on several additional points in order to guide researchers' use of VRscores or other measures related to the study of workforce politics.

7.1. Handling Missing Partisanship

As detailed previously, some workers do not appear on LinkedIn or are unregistered to vote. Another source of potential "missingness" is workers who cannot be linked with either the Democratic or Republican party. In the case of VRscores, this occurs for voters who are registered to vote but not registered with either party. Prior work focused on donations within top management teams has argued that because corporate elites are likely to be solicited for donations—and they have the financial means to do so—corporate elites who opt not to donate should be assigned a moderate or neutral ideology score equidistant between Democratic and Republican donors (e.g., Gupta and Wowak 2017, p. 12).[14] This approach asserts that nondonation is equivalent to donating equally between the two parties and that not donating is reflective of ideological preferences rather than strategic silence (Bondi et al. 2025).

Based on political science research, we argue that it is inadvisable to interpret a "missing" partisan affiliation as political neutrality. First, many "independents" are, in fact, quite similar to partisans. The majority of officially registered and/or self-described independents have clear

and consistent partisan leanings and these "leaners" behave similarly to partisans (Keith et al. 1992, Petrocik 2009, Klar 2014). Second, to the extent that unaffiliated (i.e., "independent") voters are not associated with either the Democratic or Republican party, this does not entail that they are necessarily ideologically moderate or favor middle-of-the-road policies that are in between the two major parties. Far from being moderate or middle of the road, many "swing" or "independent" voters adopt idiosyncratic and inconsistent combinations of policy positions that are more extreme than those supported by either major party (Broockman 2016).

Instead of treating independents as a politically moderate or otherwise interpretable category, we offer two measurement approaches within VRscores. The first takes a conservative approach to focus only on Democrats and Republicans as explicitly characterized by L2. As our preferred approach, we also offer a version of VRscores that includes imputed partisanship for voters who are formally unaffiliated with either major party. Rather than assuming that most unaffiliated voters are centrist, moderate, or indifferent, we follow political science research in assuming that the majority of unaffiliated voters actually "lean" closer to one party or the other (Keith et al. 1992, Petrocik 2009, Klar 2014). Our imputation approach is based upon well-established methods (Brown and Enos 2021) and is described in Online Appendix A.

These two measures could potentially be used to capture slightly different theoretical constructs. The first measure (without imputation) includes those who are more likely to readily identify with a political party. The second (imputed) measure includes those who may be less likely to formally identify with either political party—that is, leaners who do not formally claim to be Democrats or Republicans but are likely to nevertheless hold similar views and attitudes to those who formally identify as partisans. In practice, we feel these differences are minor. Empirically, these two VRscores measures are well correlated. Theoretically, studies of many political phenomena note that even those without strong partisan identities (i.e., leaners) often appear similar to stronger partisans, for example, in their positive disposition toward their own political side and negative affect toward the opposing party (i.e., affective polarization) (Druckman and Levendusky 2019). For researchers without strong theoretical reasons to prefer one measure over the other, our general suggestion would be to use imputed measures; regardless of which measure is primary, we suggest researchers report the alternative measure as a robustness check.

7.2. Quantifying Uncertainty

Nearly all existing studies of workforce politics have been limited to focusing on a small subset of very large firms (e.g., the S&P 500) (see Table A1 in the Online Appendix). VRscores unlock the possibility of studying a much broader set of firms. However, this expanded coverage necessarily entails some trade-offs. Whereas we do not provide VRscore estimates for firms with fewer than five matched employees, some estimates may still be derived based upon a relatively small number of workers. Because VRscores are sample proportions, their precision scales with $1/\sqrt{n}$, where n is the number of matched workers per firm.[15] Therefore, estimates based on fewer matched workers, whether because of smaller underlying firm size or lower match rates, will tend to be noisier. We do not provide estimates for firms with fewer than five workers and encourage researchers to exercise particular caution when analyzing firms with small numbers of matched workers.

Empirically, within-firm temporal variability in VRscores is a clear negative function of firm size. Firms with 1,000 or more matched employees exhibit average within-firm standard deviations below 0.05, whereas small firms show substantially greater variability, with standard deviations of approximately 0.3. We provide a panel with annual estimates of firm-level VRscores, but we urge caution in interpreting year-over-year changes in partisanship as explanatory or control variables (especially for firms with smaller absolute numbers of workers), as small measurement errors may lead to biased estimates (Card 1996).

8. Potential Applications for VRscores

We believe VRscores will facilitate research into a wide range of questions, including those of direct interest to management and strategy scholars, as well as broader questions regarding business, politics, and democracy that cut across academic disciplines.

8.1. Performance

First, VRscores can serve as a valuable tool for understanding how workers' partisanship relates to organizational performance. Whereas an extensive literature has considered how the racial and gender composition of workplaces relates to financial performance (Richard 2000, Dezső and Ross 2012, Hoogendoorn et al. 2013, Karpowitz et al. 2024), much less is known regarding the possible relationships between financial performance and political composition. This gap is critical in light of the fact that political sorting across workplaces is similar in magnitude to segregation by race and gender (Colonnelli et al. 2022, Chinoy and Koenen 2024, de Figueiredo et al. 2024, Frake et al. 2024). On the one hand, political diversity could yield benefits such as expanded perspectives that can enable creative problem solving or better relationships with other politically diverse stakeholders. Given evidence of political segregation across occupations (Frake et al. 2024) as well as evidence of preferences for copartisan coworkers (Gift

and Gift 2015, Roth et al. 2022, Hurst and Lee 2025), failure to cultivate a politically diverse workplace may make it difficult to attract or retain workers. On the other hand, political diversity may dampen performance by sparking conflict and disagreements among employees, leading to lower productivity and higher turnover (Bermiss and McDonald 2018, Swigart et al. 2020, Barber and Blake 2024).

Taking a different perspective, future work might examine how political composition changes as a result of performance. Shared victories in workplace contexts might erode distrust across political lines, raising the salience of "cross-cutting" workplace identities over partisan identities (Mutz and Mondak 2006, Van Assche et al. 2023). This may reduce internal divisions or turnover related to political disagreement, contributing to united but politically diverse workplaces. Alternatively, improved labor market conditions arising from good performance could increase employees' market power, facilitating political minorities' ability to switch into workplaces with a greater share of copartisan coworkers.

8.2. Sociopolitical Positioning and Corporate Social Responsibility

Additionally, VRscores provide a tool for understanding the connection between rank-and-file workers and employers' inclination to take stances on divisive sociopolitical issues. Existing theories regarding sociopolitical positioning point to the key role that workers play in shaping these decisions (Hurst 2023, Mohliver et al. 2023). Using the donations-based approach, some work has begun to empirically examine these relationships (Li and Disalvo 2023, McKean and King 2024, Seo 2024). Research leveraging VRscores will be able to provide further insight regarding the connection between workers' partisanship and employers' sociopolitical stance taking. Future work might also use VRscores as an outcome variable, examining, for example, how stance taking on the political left or right shapes the longer-term political composition of the employee population. Relatedly, VRscores can be used to further understand the connection between workers' politics and employers' social responsibility (Gupta et al. 2017). One extension might be to examine CSR-related outcomes among the large number of employers for which there are no donors but for which we are able to calculate a VRscore. These could provide insight into the roles of employees within smaller, local organizations in shaping social outcomes.

8.3. Broader Sociopolitical Outcomes

Finally, whereas strategy and management scholars comprise our main audience for this paper, we believe VRscores will also be of use to the growing number of scholars across the social sciences who study the role of firms and their employees in the broader political landscape (e.g., Li and Disalvo 2023, Chinoy and Koenen 2024). In the same way that Bonica (2014)'s CFscores have become a staple for studying money in politics, we believe VRscores can become a staple in studying business and politics, not only among management and strategy scholars but also scholars in marketing, organizational behavior, finance, as well as other non-business-school disciplines such as political science, psychology, economics, and sociology. Each of these disciplines now has active research communities examining the role of partisan politics in workplace settings. In fact, beyond the firm-level outcomes of most interest to management scholars, VRscores can be used to examine broader sociopolitical phenomena, including electoral outcomes, voter turnout, campaign strategy, affective polarization, and more.

8.4. Studying Donations

In presenting VRscores, we do not argue that scholars should abandon the study of political donations. Political donations are a critical object of study in and of themselves. For example, donations can be used as an outcome variable for characterizing firms' nonmarket strategy (Li and Disalvo 2023) or an explanatory variable that may (or may not) allow firms to achieve key strategic objectives (Werner 2015). Neither of these approaches requires assuming that donations capture deeply held political identity or ideology.

Moreover, insights might be gleaned by combining donations and voter-based measures of worker politics. For example, do partisan workers donate to outpartisan candidates to match the donation behavior of coworkers or employer PACs? When PACs and upper echelons donate in ways contrary to the partisanship of the broader employee population, does this "mismatch" have downstream implications for employees' effort or turnover? Another avenue may be to test for a firm-level analog to Bafumi and Herron (2010)'s theory of "leapfrog representation," wherein small numbers of exceptionally politically active donors disproportionately drive firms' sociopolitical actions. Scholars may also find it useful to combine donations and voter registrations to create multidimensional measures of organizational politics. For example, employers with high shares of registered Democrats, as well as high numbers and shares of donations to Democratic candidates, might be characterized as exceptionally left leaning.

Finally, there may be cases where donations might reasonably be used to capture workers' political identities or ideologies. For example, prior studies have shown that donations provide significant coverage of highly detailed, comprehensive professional databases of white-collar professions, that is, lawyers (Bonica et al. 2016, Carnahan and Greenwood 2018) and doctors (Kim 2025). Notably, these studies do not use donations to characterize the political ideology or

identity of entire organizations and focus on populations for which questions over strategic donations seem less salient. If scholars are specifically interested in capturing ideology, we suggest using CFscores from the DIME database (Bonica 2014), which permit fine-grained distinctions.

9. Conclusion

Our study makes several contributions toward understanding how employees' political partisanship shapes organizational outcomes. First, we describe a novel methodology for linking voter files to workers, allowing scholars to characterize workers' partisanship for a sizable share of the U.S. labor market. Second, we use this methodology to create a measure of workplace partisanship, VRscores. Third, we demonstrate—both empirically and conceptually—the advantages of VRscores relative to donations-based measures. VRscores provide far broader and deeper coverage of the workforce and more representative sampling across organizational levels and industries. Finally, we discuss a range of potential uses for this new measure, describing how it may be applied to questions related to firm performance, innovation, sociopolitical stance taking, corporate social responsibility, and broader political phenomena.

Our article is closely related to literature that has used donations-based approaches to examine the role of workers' political ideologies in shaping organizational outcomes. This literature has made critical contributions, drawing attention to important questions and providing preliminary evidence that workers may shape their employers' engagement with social issues (Gupta et al. 2017, Li and Disalvo 2023, McKean and King 2024). This paper complements and extends this work, demonstrating that donations-based measures of ideology are heavily skewed toward wealthier workers higher up in organizational hierarchies and presenting VRscores as a measure of partisanship that better captures rank-and-file workers.

Notably, some contemporary work has begun to merge voter files and worker profiles to study related questions, including estimates of the overall degree of political partisan segregation in the United States (Chinoy and Koenen 2024, Frake et al. 2024), as well as more specific studies on inventors (de Figueiredo et al. 2024), patent examiners (Raffiee et al. 2023), and startups (Kovács and Sels 2025). Whereas our data provide a firm-level breakdown of political composition across employers, it does not examine the causes of political sorting across employers. Some work highlights how labor market political sorting may be downstream from sorting that occurs across geographies, occupations, and industries (Frake et al. 2024), whereas other work points to the potential impact of partisan language in the course of recruiting (Roth et al. 2022, Chinoy and Koenen 2024, Hurst and Lee 2025). More work is needed to understand these origins. We hope VRscores can be used in future work to provide further insight into these questions.

In the context of growing political polarization, employers are entering the political arena in unprecedented ways (Larcker et al. 2018, Barari 2024, Grossmann and Hopkins 2024). Given the potentially critical role that workers play in shaping these actions, it is critical to have wide-reaching, representative measures of workers' politics. There is much to be done regarding how employees' politics shape organizational and societal outcomes, and we believe VRscores will be useful in these efforts and advance the growing body of research on this important topic.

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Endnotes

[1] Variants of this measure may focus on specific types of employees within a company, for example, board members, executives, or other subpopulations of interest. They may also consist of one or more different measures, such as the number of donations, the dollar amount, or the number of distinct recipients.

[2] The papers are individually listed in Table A1 in the Online Appendix. The journals were *Academy of Management Review* (AMR), *Academy of Management Journal* (AMJ), *Administrative Science Quarterly* (ASQ), *Management Science* (MS), *Organization Science* (OS), and *Strategic Management Journal* (SMJ). We searched each journal using the keywords "donat*," "democrat*," and "republic*" and then manually reviewed results; we did not find any empirical papers in AMR. We include all papers appearing in these journals from 2010 to 2024 (the first paper appeared in 2013), which includes papers in strategy and management as well as accounting, finance, and marketing. This does not include a number of relevant papers that are published in other disciplinary journals.

[3] Whereas it is possible to download or purchase these data from each state individually, it is logistically complicated and expensive to do so.

[4] The data are hosted at the Harvard Dataverse and can also be accessed via https://politicsatwork.org/.

[5] Whereas one can infer that those who donate to both parties are Independent (as we do here), the common practice of treating non-donors as politically "neutral" has little empirical backing, as most

Americans express support for one of the two major parties despite never having made political donations (Keith et al. 1992, Klar and Krupnikov 2016). We return to this point in Section 7.

[6] We also conduct the same analysis using the share of donation dollars rather than the number of individual donors; the results are nearly identical and are shown in Figure A1 in the Online Appendix.

[7] Anecdotal reports also confirm that both corporate elites and politicians view executives' personal donations as substitutes for one another: for example, Clawson et al. (1998) report one instance in which staff for Senator John Kerry solicited personal donations from executives in lieu of donations from their corporate PAC after Senator Kerry promised not to accept corporate PAC dollars (cited in Teso 2025, p. 28).

[8] The same may also arguably be true of some donations-based measures. Some donations-based measures, such as Adam Bonica's DIME (Bonica 2016), are designed to measure ideology as a continuous measure (Poole 1998) and so can distinguish intraparty variation. By contrast, donations-based measures commonly used in management focus on dichotomous measures of partisan donation patterns and so might arguably be described as reflecting partisan identity rather than ideology, although they have not typically been described as such.

[9] Revelio describes its data collection process as aggregating "publicly available professional profiles," which may include international competitors to LinkedIn such as Germany's XING; in the United States, we believe that nearly all of its employment information is sourced from LinkedIn.

[10] For example, higher education and Silicon Valley technology firms may employ large numbers of noncitizen workers who are likely very politically active, whereas agricultural firms may employ large numbers of immigrants—including some without legal employment authorization—who may be less politically engaged.

[11] Beyond noncitizens, VRscores also do not capture those who have been legally disenfranchised—most notably, convicted felons. Felons without the right to vote comprise about 2% of the full population and an even smaller fraction of the working population (Uggen et al. 2022, Hwang and Phillips 2024). Although this population is not captured by voter registrations, it is unlikely that donations-based measures will perform meaningfully better at capturing this group. Whereas there does not appear to be any specific legal prohibition on campaign donations by convicted felons, it seems unlikely that a large number of convicted felons are active campaign donors.

[12] State parties differ in the eligibility to vote in partisan primaries. Some states offer "open" primaries in which any registered voter in the state may choose to vote in that party's primary. Others are "closed" or "semiclosed" and are open only to voters who are registered to that party and/or who were previously unaffiliated with any party. Finally, some states have nonpartisan primaries with a single ballot that lists all candidates (Brown and Enos 2021). States with closed or semiclosed primaries are Arizona, Alaska (only Republicans), Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, DC, Florida, Idaho, Kansas, Kentucky, Maine, Maryland, Massachusetts, Nebraska, Nevada, New Hampshire, New Jersey, New Mexico, New York, North Carolina, Oklahoma, Oregon, Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, South Dakota, Utah, and West Virginia.

[13] States typically do not allow access to individual records but instead sell the entire voter roll to interested parties, such as researchers, political parties, and data brokers. Many states charge significant access fees of hundreds or thousands of dollars; data vendors also charge significant fees and may have burdensome methods of accessing the data (e.g., by physically mailing a CD-ROM).

[14] The approach of treating nondonors as ideologically moderate has been tested in a single voluntary-response survey of university alumni ($n = 106$). Although this study found a moderate correlation between self-reported seven-point ideology and a donations-based score that included imputed neutral ideology for nondonors ($r = 0.51$), this population likely differs in very significant ways from more senior executives at larger firms, and the voluntary response nature of this sample is likely subject to the same selection biases present in using public donations records. See Chin et al. (2013, pp. 209–210).

[15] A larger sample does not address selection bias from nonrandom sampling. We acknowledge that our sample is, by necessity, nonrandom.

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